WAVERLEY GATEWAY GUIDE

Connecting International Capital with Emerging & Frontier Markets

SINT MAARTEN

Americas

Information current as of October 2026

Dialogue | Trust | Partnership

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WHERE AND HOW TO ENTER

KEY INVESTMENT LOCATIONS

Location / Region	Strategic Importance	Priority Sectors
Philipsburg	Capital and commercial centre of this autonomous constituent country of the Kingdom of the Netherlands, home to government, banking and the island's main shopping district	Retail, financial and professional services, hospitality, administration
Port St. Maarten (Dr. A.C. Wathey Cruise and Cargo Facilities)	One of the Caribbean's busiest cruise ports, handling 1.6 million cruise passengers and 592 ship calls in 2025, with Disney Cruise Line expanding to around 14 calls in 2027	Cruise services, cargo and logistics, shore excursions, retail
Princess Juliana International Airport (Simpson Bay)	Rebuilt terminal recommissioned in November 2024 with capacity for 2.5 million passengers a year; main air gateway for Anguilla, Saba, St Barthélemy and St Eustatius	Aviation and airlift, air cargo, aviation services, airport-linked commerce
Simpson Bay Lagoon and marinas	Sheltered lagoon shared with the French side that attracts yachts and supports a marine-services cluster, a Tier 1 priority in the government's diversification strategy	Yachting, marinas, marine services and training
Dawn Beach and Indigo Bay	Focus of upscale resort development, including the JW Marriott at Dawn Beach and the planned 205-room Setai resort at Indigo Bay, expected in 2028	Luxury hotels, branded residences, real estate
New St. Maarten General Hospital	Hurricane-resilient hospital built to Category 5 standards with 108 seismic base isolators, which reached topping out in March 2026	Healthcare services, medical tourism, facilities management
Open border with French Saint-Martin	The island's two sides form a single visitor and consumer market, giving Dutch-side businesses reach into the French Collectivity	Retail, distribution, tourism and services

INVESTOR ENTRY ROUTES

- Ministry of Tourism, Economic Affairs, Transport and Telecommunication (TEATT) handles business licensing and investment policy, and in August 2026 commissioned the framework for a proposed Sint Maarten Investment Promotion Agency with one-stop investor services

- Investment Policy and Diversification Strategy (2022) prioritising niche tourism, the marine industry, agriculture technology, an airport-city logistics hub and medical tourism
- Tax investment deduction of 8% (12% for real estate other than land) on qualifying investments above Cg 5,000, with ten-year loss carry-forward; a Penshonado regime taxes qualifying foreign income of new residents at 10%
- Caribbean guilder (Cg), introduced on 31 March 2025 and fixed at Cg 1.79 = $1.00, managed by the Centrale Bank van Curaçao en Sint Maarten (CBCS), which also licenses and supervises financial institutions; the US dollar is widely used
- Sint Maarten Reconstruction, Recovery and Resilience Trust Fund, financed by the Netherlands and managed by the World Bank until December 2028, procuring contractors and consultants for infrastructure, health and resilience projects
- Partnership and concession routes with state-linked companies such as Port St. Maarten and the Princess Juliana International Airport operating company for port, aviation and logistics projects
- Company registration through the Chamber of Commerce, with ultimate beneficial owner (UBO) reporting now required for legal entities

MARKET-ENTRY OBSERVATION

Sint Maarten enters late 2026 with steady growth and improving public finances. The CBCS estimates real GDP growth of 3.4% in 2025 and projects 2.4% for 2026, driven by tourism, construction, transport and trade. Cruise arrivals rose 16% to 1,597,940 in 2025, close to their pre-Irma peak, while the airport recorded 855,994 arriving passengers and around 1.8 million passengers in total. The IMF projects government debt to fall from 44.2% of GDP in 2024 to 40.4% in 2025 and 38.4% in 2026, with inflation of 3.6% in 2024 expected to ease towards 2%. At monetary-union level, the current account deficit narrowed from 16.4% to 9.2% of GDP in 2025, and reserves covered 5.5 months of imports at end-May 2026, comfortably supporting the dollar peg, with the CBCS pledging rate at 4.25%.

Sint Maarten's main structural challenge is its exposure to Atlantic hurricanes in a tourism-centred economy: Hurricane Irma in 2017 caused damage estimated at 129% of GDP. The country has since rebuilt with resilience in mind, supported by €550 million set aside by the Netherlands, most of it channelled through the World Bank-managed Trust Fund running to December 2028. The rebuilt airport terminal was recommissioned in November 2024, and the new Category 5-resilient general hospital reached topping out in March 2026, while the existing hospital kept operating through Hurricane Erin in August 2025. The IMF's priority is to shift investment from Trust Fund-led projects to private investment, faster permitting and higher-value tourism, creating openings in resilient construction, renewable energy, marine services and upscale hospitality for investors who build resilience into project design.

INVESTOR RISK & MARKET ACCESS

KEY ENTRY BARRIERS

Issue	Potential Impact	Possible Mitigation
Hurricane exposure	Sint Maarten lies in the Atlantic hurricane belt; Irma in 2017 caused damage estimated at 129% of GDP	Resilient design, insurance and business-continuity planning are standard; post-Irma rebuilding has raised building and infrastructure standards, creating demand for resilient construction
Concentration on tourism	Hotels, restaurants and related services account for about 45% of GDP and tourism for 73% of foreign-exchange earnings	Record cruise traffic and new airlift support the core sector, while the diversification strategy opens marine, logistics, agri-tech and medical-tourism niches
Permitting and project execution	The IMF notes a building-permit backlog that has delayed hotel and real estate projects, and uncertainty over delivery capacity once the Trust Fund closes in 2028	Engage the relevant ministries and experienced local advisers early; the planned investment promotion agency and permit digitalisation should shorten timelines
Electricity supply and costs	Power relies largely on conventional generation, and the IMF has called for a stronger regulator and a transition to	The utility GEBE is seeking land for its first solar project, opening opportunities in solar, storage and efficiency

Issue	Potential Impact	Possible Mitigation
	renewables	
AML/CFT framework	The 2025 mutual evaluation rated effectiveness as low on 9 of 11 outcomes, and the IMF has called for major upgrades	Beneficial-ownership reporting is now in force; working with reputable local banks and advisers and robust compliance programmes supports smooth entry
Budget timeliness and fiscal oversight	The 2026 budget was submitted late, and budgets are reviewed by the Board of Financial Supervision (Cft) under Kingdom law	Kingdom supervision anchors fiscal discipline, and debt is projected to keep falling towards 38% of GDP in 2026
Small labour market and skills	The IMF highlights the need for private job creation, formalisation and targeted skills training	Investors offering training and partnering with local institutions can strengthen their workforce and align with government priorities

INVESTOR RISK NOTE

Sint Maarten's risk profile is that of a stable, dollar-pegged island economy within the Kingdom of the Netherlands, with growing tourism, declining public debt and the institutional backing of Kingdom financial supervision and a shared central bank. The main considerations are exposure to hurricanes, reliance on tourism, permitting delays and continued work on the AML/CFT framework following the 2025 mutual evaluation. Each is being addressed: post-Irma reconstruction has delivered a rebuilt airport and a hurricane-resilient hospital, the government is developing an investment promotion agency and a diversification strategy, and beneficial-ownership reporting is now in force. Investors should plan for hurricane-resilient design and insurance, allow time for permits, and apply strong compliance standards. With cruise traffic close to pre-Irma levels, new luxury resorts in the pipeline and significant reconstruction investment still to be deployed before 2028, the outlook remains constructive.

MARKET ACCESS

Sint Maarten is an autonomous constituent country of the Kingdom of the Netherlands. It is not part of the EU but is associated with it as an Overseas Country and Territory (OCT), which gives it preferential access to the EU market and eligibility for EU cooperation funding, and its nationals hold Dutch and therefore EU citizenship. It participates in the WTO through the Kingdom of the Netherlands and shares a monetary union and central bank with Curaçao. The open border with French Saint-Martin creates a single island market, and Princess Juliana International Airport is the main air gateway for the surrounding Leeward Islands. Services are the main export, led by tourism, with North America supplying about two-thirds of stay-over visitors and Europe about a quarter. Port St. Maarten's cruise and cargo facilities anchor the island's role as a regional hub for visitors, distribution and yachting.

WHO SHOULD THE INVESTOR MEET?

INSTITUTIONAL LANDSCAPE

Actor	Why It Matters	Waverley Engagement Angle
Office of the Prime Minister (Dr Luc Mercelina)	Leads the government, in office since May 2024, and manages relations with the Netherlands on Trust Fund and reform matters	Primary reference point for strategic priorities and Kingdom relations
Ministry of Tourism, Economic Affairs, Transport and Telecommunication (TEATT)	Issues business licences, leads tourism and investment policy and is developing the proposed investment promotion agency	Standard first point of contact for market entry, licensing and introductions
Centrale Bank van Curaçao en Sint Maarten (CBCS)	Maintains the Caribbean guilder peg, sets the 4.25% pledging rate and supervises banks and financial institutions	Relevant for banking, licensing and foreign-exchange matters
Ministry of Finance and the Board of Financial Supervision (Cft)	The ministry sets tax and budget policy, while the Cft reviews budgets under the Kingdom Act on Financial Supervision	Relevant for tax treatment, public-finance outlook and public-investment pipeline

Actor	Why It Matters	Waverley Engagement Angle
Sint Maarten Trust Fund (World Bank) and National Recovery Program Bureau (NRPB)	Netherlands-financed reconstruction and resilience programme managed by the World Bank to December 2028, with the NRPB as implementing agency	Key channel for contracting and consultancy opportunities in reconstruction projects
Port St. Maarten	Operates the cruise and cargo facilities that handled 1.6 million cruise passengers in 2025	Essential partner for cruise, cargo, logistics and waterfront investment
Princess Juliana International Airport	State-owned airport rebuilt after Irma and recommissioned in 2024, serving as the gateway to the northern Leeward Islands	Key counterpart for airlift, aviation services and airport-city development

CURRENT INTERNATIONAL BUSINESS CHANNELS

The Chamber of Commerce and Industry is the business registry and main liaison body for the private sector, and TEATT is consulting businesses and investors in 2026 on the design of the planned investment promotion agency. The World Bank-managed Trust Fund publishes tenders and results and is a practical route into reconstruction and resilience projects until 2028. Kingdom channels, including the Dutch government and the Cft, shape larger public projects, while Sint Maarten's OCT status gives access to EU cooperation programmes, including funding for culture and the creative economy. The IMF's Article IV reviews, conducted jointly with Curaçao, and the CBCS economic bulletins provide independent references on policy direction.

INVESTOR PROFILE BEST SUITED

Sint Maarten suits investors seeking a dollar-pegged jurisdiction within the Kingdom of the Netherlands with a strong tourism franchise: upscale hotel, resort and residential developers serving growing North American and European demand; cruise, aviation and logistics businesses building on a busy port and rebuilt airport; construction, engineering and consultancy firms able to deliver hurricane-resilient infrastructure and Trust Fund contracts; and renewable-energy, storage and efficiency investors supporting the power transition. Marine and yachting businesses, healthcare and medical-tourism operators, and agri-tech ventures aligned with the diversification strategy can also find attractive niches, provided they build in strong compliance and resilience planning.

FROM INTELLIGENCE TO ENGAGEMENT

STEP 1: Engage TEATT and the emerging investment promotion agency
Open dialogue with the ministry on licensing, priority sectors and sites, and contribute to the consultation shaping the new investment promotion agency.

STEP 2: Map Trust Fund and public-investment opportunities
Track World Bank Trust Fund tenders and the government's infrastructure pipeline before the Trust Fund closes in December 2028.

STEP 3: Build hurricane resilience into project design and insurance
Apply post-Irma building standards, secure appropriate cover and plan business continuity from the outset.

STEP 4: Plan permits, tax and compliance early
Allow time for building and business permits, confirm tax treatment with local advisers, and prepare for CBCS licensing and beneficial-ownership requirements.

STEP 5: Align with tourism growth and diversification priorities
Use port, airport and visitor data to target hospitality, airlift, marine, renewable-energy and medical-tourism opportunities.